

A Month of Sundays

Every Sunday he walked to the same bench. Nobody had ever sat with him. Until now.

CEFR Level B1

Book 3 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A small park in a northern English city. Sunday mornings, across four weeks.

Genre: Warm Drama / Intergenerational

Characters

- Arthur — 81. Widower. Retired engineer. Has walked to the park every Sunday for twenty-two years.
- Priya — 31. Junior doctor in her first year of a hospital rotation. Exhausted, temporarily lost.
- The bench — a fixed point in both their lives, for different reasons.

Arthur had been coming to this bench every Sunday morning for twenty-two years.

He had begun the habit the week after Dorothy died — something to do with himself on Sunday mornings, which had been her time, not his. The park, the bench, the hour of sitting: these had become a kind of anchor.

He had never shared it with anyone. This was not a complaint.

On the first Sunday of October, a young woman sat down at the other end of the bench.

She had a paper cup of coffee and she was staring at the middle distance with the expression of someone who had not slept and had been awake long enough that it no longer felt like tiredness.

He did not particularly want to read and a flask of tea he had made before he left the house.

The young woman did not say anything either. She drank her coffee slowly, looking at the trees.

The trees were turning — orange and yellow, very particular to this time of year. Arthur had always liked October, which surprised people when he mentioned it. People seemed to expect old men to prefer summer.

After forty minutes, the young woman stood up, put her cup in the bin, and walked away.

She did not look back. Arthur watched her go, then looked at the trees.

She had a different cup of coffee — from a different café, he noted, because the logo was different. She looked slightly less hollowed out than she had the week before, though not entirely.

Arthur had spent some time during the week thinking about whether to say something.

He had decided: not yet. People who needed company without conversation were not rare. He had been one himself.

He poured a cup of tea from his flask and continued not speaking.

'Do you come here every week?' she asked. She had not turned towards him — she was asking the trees.

'Every Sunday for twenty-two years,' Arthur said.

She turned then. 'Twenty-two years.' 'Yes.' 'Is that a record?' 'I don't know. It might be a habit.'

'What's the difference?' Arthur thought about this. 'A record is something you achieve. A habit is something you fall into because the alternative is worse.'

She looked at the trees again. 'That's quite honest,' she said.

'At eighty-one you stop bothering to be anything else.'

She told him — in the third Sunday's second silence, after the conversation about habits — that she was a junior doctor in the first year of a hospital rotation.

'A rotation,' he repeated. 'You rotate.' 'Yes. Different departments, different hospitals. Every four months.'

'Does it suit you?' 'I don't know yet. I think I would suit it better if I'd slept recently.'

He asked how long since she had slept properly. She said she wasn't sure — several weeks, in the sense that she slept but not restoratively.

'Restoratively,' he said. 'Good word.' 'I'm a doctor,' she said. 'I have good words for things that are broken.'

On the fourth Sunday, which was also the last Sunday of October, Arthur told her about Dorothy.

He did not plan this. It happened because she had asked why he had started coming to the bench, and he had found, unusually, that he wanted to answer.

'My wife died twenty-two years ago,' he said. 'Dorothy. Breast cancer. Very fast — eight weeks from diagnosis to the end.'

'I'm sorry,' Priya said. She said it the way a doctor would — not performatively, but as a fact she was acknowledging.

'Sunday mornings were hers,' Arthur said. 'She always had plans. I never did. After she went, I had to find something to do with myself. I found this.'

He asked, in turn.

She had thought about how to answer for most of the walk to the park.

'I made a mistake,' she said. 'In my last rotation. Nothing catastrophic — no one was harmed. But I made a call that turned out to be wrong, and I knew it was borderline when I made it, and I made it anyway because I was tired and it was four in the morning.'

'What happened?' 'The patient was fine. My supervisor found out and we discussed it and she told me that I had done what most doctors would have done in those circumstances and that I shouldn't be too hard on myself.'

'But you are,' Arthur said.

'Yes,' Priya said. 'I am.'

'I was an engineer,' he said. 'Bridge and structural. For forty years. If I had made a call like that — borderline, exhausted, four in the morning — I would have caused a collapse. People would have died.'

'That's worse,' Priya said.

'Yes. Which is why we were not allowed to work in conditions like that. We had strict rules. Shifts of no more than ten hours on anything critical. Mandatory rest periods.' He paused. 'What are your shift hours?'

Priya told him.

Arthur said nothing for a moment. 'That seems,' he said carefully, 'like a great deal to ask of a person.'

November arrived, and with it a different quality of cold.

Arthur came to the bench in his heavier coat and wore his hat. Priya arrived in a coat she had clearly bought for a warmer city — thin wool, inadequate.

'You should have a warmer coat,' Arthur said, which was the closest he had come to saying something direct.

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Arthur walks to the same bench every Sunday, as he always has.

'I know,' she said. 'I bought this in London. I didn't think about November.'

'You were expecting summer,' he said.

She laughed. It was the first time he had heard her laugh. It was a good one — sudden and real.

'I suppose I was,' she said. 'I always do that. I expect things to stay like they were.'

He had thought, over the years, quite a lot about what he had learned from Dorothy's death.

The main thing — the thing he had taken the longest to understand — was this: grief was not the same as the absence of a person. Grief was the accumulated weight of every version of them you had not yet grieved — the future versions, the ones who would have been seventy, seventy-five, eighty, who would have had opinions about things and been difficult about other things.

He did not say this to Priya directly. He was not sure it was relevant.

But he thought about it when she said she always expected things to stay like they were.

He thought: she has not yet understood that they won't. She will.

By December, the bench had become, without discussion, theirs in some limited sense.

They arrived at roughly the same time. They sat for the same length of time. They talked more than they had in October, which was not difficult.

He had told her about Dorothy, and about his work, and about his son in New Zealand whom he had not seen in four years and who called on birthdays and was a good man with a busy life.

She had told him about her family in Leicester — her parents, her sister who was a solicitor — and about the patient she had been worrying about in October, who had been discharged and was now, she believed, doing well.

'You hadn't told me that before,' Arthur said.

'I wasn't sure if it was resolved. I don't like to tell incomplete stories.'

limited sense sınırlı anlamda "I don't like to tell incomplete stories." Arthur understands this precisely.

The last Sunday before Christmas, Priya brought two cups of coffee — one for each of them.

This was the first time she had brought something for him, and he found it moving in a way he had not expected.

'I didn't know how you take it,' she said. 'I got it black.'

'Black is fine,' he said. It was not exactly true. He preferred tea. But he drank the coffee and it was good.

They talked about Christmas — she was going to Leicester, he was staying. His son had asked if he wanted to come to New Zealand. He had said no.

'Don't you want to see him?' 'Of course. But I don't want to spend Christmas on a plane.'

'You should visit him,' she said.

'I know,' he said. 'I should have gone years ago.'

spend Christmas on a plane Noel'i uçakta geçirmek
years ago yıllar önce "I should have gone years ago." He
says should have — past regret entering the conversation.
She came back after Christmas changed in a way he could
not immediately identify.

Not different in the large sense — she was still tired, still
careful. But something had shifted in her quality of
stillness.

He asked how Christmas had been.

'My sister took me on a walk,' she said. 'A long walk. She
said I needed to be physically tired, not just mentally tired,
and that the park on Sunday mornings was not enough.'

'Was she right?' 'Yes. I slept for eleven hours that night and
felt like myself for the first time since September.'

'Your sister sounds like a good doctor,' Arthur said.

'She's a solicitor,' Priya said. 'But yes.'

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Priya sits beside him, and a quiet routine becomes a conversation.

In February, Priya told him she had put in a request to extend her rotation at the hospital by three months.

'I thought you were leaving in April,' Arthur said.

'I was. But I've started to understand it here. The department, the rhythms. Starting again in a new place would have meant losing that. The consultant agreed it made clinical sense.'

Arthur looked at the park, which was brown and bare and perfectly itself.

'What changed?' he asked.

She thought about this. 'I stopped expecting it to be different from what it is. Which sounds simple, but it took longer than it should have done.'

'Most important things do,' he said.

In March, Arthur told her he had booked a flight to New Zealand.

He had not planned to do this. He had called his son on a Sunday evening to talk — something he did less often than he should have — and halfway through the call his son had said, 'Dad, I'd really like to see you,' and it had been said in a particular way that required a particular response.

He had booked the flight that night.

'Good,' Priya said, when he told her. 'I'm glad.' 'I'll miss the park,' he said.

'The park will be here. How long?' 'Three weeks.' 'Will you come back to the bench?'

He looked at her. 'I've been coming here for twenty-two years,' he said. 'I will be here.'

He had not told his son how long it had been since he had left the city for more than a day. He thought his son probably knew and was tactfully not mentioning it.

His son's house was in a suburb of Auckland, near the sea. It was warm and full of light and entirely unlike anything he was used to.

He stayed for three weeks and three days — slightly longer than planned.

His son's children, whom he had met only on video calls, were eight and twelve. They asked him questions with a directness that he found refreshing.

The twelve-year-old asked: 'What do you do on Sundays?' 'I sit on a bench,' Arthur said. 'And sometimes I talk to a doctor.'

video calls görüntülü aramalar "I sit on a bench and sometimes I talk to a doctor." His whole winter in one sentence.

cherry trees, the first roses, everything aggressively alive after a long winter.

Priya was on the bench when he arrived.

She had brought two coffees.

'Welcome back,' she said.

'Thank you,' he said. He sat down. The bench felt entirely correct — the right height, the right aspect, facing the right trees.

He had been sitting on this bench for twenty-three years.

'How was New Zealand?' 'Warm,' he said. 'Very warm. And very good. I should have gone earlier.'

'You went when you were ready,' she said.

He looked at her. 'Yes,' he said. 'I suppose I did.'

He had thought, on the plane back from Auckland, about what the bench had been.

For twenty-two years, it had been the thing he did instead of grief — the weekly ritual that held the shape of Sunday morning without requiring anything of him emotionally.

This year, it had been something else. It had been a conversation — and not just the conversations with Priya, but the conversations with himself that the park had always made possible.

Dorothy had always said he was better at thinking outdoors.

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By the end of the month, the bench belongs to both of them.

He had thought she meant walking. He understood now that she had meant all of it — the cold, the changing light, the other people, the unremarkable continuity of a park on a Sunday morning.

In June, Priya told him she was leaving the city at the end of the month.

The rotation extension was ending, and she had been offered a position in a different hospital — closer to Leicester, closer to her family, in a department she had decided she wanted to specialise in.

'Emergency medicine,' she said. 'Unexpected. But right.'

'When did you decide?' 'I think I've been deciding all year. I just didn't have the words for it until recently.'

He thought about this. He thought about Dorothy, and about Priya, and about conversations that happened on benches in parks over a long winter.

'Will you have a bench?' he asked.

She smiled. 'I'll find one.'

On her last Sunday, they stayed an hour longer than usual.

They talked about Dorothy and about the borderline call and about New Zealand and about emergency medicine and about the year, which had been, for both of them, something other than what they had expected.

She said she would write to him. He said he would be on the bench.

When she stood up to leave, she did something he had not anticipated: she shook his hand, formally, the way doctors do.

He appreciated the formality. It acknowledged the seriousness of what had passed between them without making more of it than it was.

'Thank you,' she said.

'Thank you,' he said.

She walked away. He watched her go. Then he looked at the trees.

acknowledged kabul etti seriousness ciddiyeti what had
passed between them aralarından geçen şey
other than what they expected beklediklerinden farklı
He looked at the trees. Twenty-three years of Sundays.
This one had been the best.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story so the reading pages remain in a natural storybook format.

1. anchor	çapa, tutunma noktası
2. complaint	şikayet
3. middle distance	orta mesafe
4. habit	alışkanlık
5. tiredness	yorgunluk
6. staring	bakıyordu
7. flask of tea	çay termosu
8. turning (leaves)	renk değiştiriyor (yapraklar)
9. particular to	... e özgü
10. mentioned it	söz etti
11. prefer	tercih etmek
12. looked back	geri baktı
13. hollowed out	içi boşalmış
14. noted	fark etti
15. rare	nadir
16. continued	devam etti
17. company without conversation	konuşmasız arkadaşlık
18. logo	logo
19. turned towards	... e döndü
20. achieve	başarmak
21. alternative	alternatif
22. bothering to be	olmaya zahmet etmek
23. honest	dürüst
24. fall into	içine düşmek
25. rotation	rotasyon
26. restoratively	yenileyici şekilde
27. departments	bölümler, servisler
28. suit you	sana uymak
29. broken	bozuk
30. recently	son zamanlarda
31. diagnosis	teşhis
32. performatively	göstermelik olarak
33. acknowledging	kabul ederek
34. plan	plan
35. unusually	alışılmadık şekilde
36. fast	hızlı
37. catastrophic	felaket
38. harmed	zarar görmüş

39. borderline	sınır çizgisinde
40. supervisor	amir, üst
41. circumstances	koşullar
42. turned out to be wrong	yanlış çıktı
43. structural	yapısal
44. collapse	çöküş
45. mandatory	zorunlu
46. shift hours	vardiya saatleri
47. critical	kritik
48. a great deal to ask	çok şey istemek
49. inadequate	yetersiz
50. thin wool	ince yün
51. quality of cold	soğuğun niteliği
52. direct	doğrudan
53. expecting summer	yaz beklemek
54. sudden	ani
55. accumulated weight	birikmiş ağırlık
56. grief	yas
57. version	sürüm, versiyonu
58. relevant	alakalı
59. understood	anlamış
60. directly	doğrudan
61. discharged	taburcu edildi
62. solicitor	avukat
63. incomplete stories	yarım hikayeler
64. resolved	çözüme kavuşmuş
65. roughly the same time	kabaca aynı zaman
66. moving	dokunaklı
67. preferred	tercih ederdi
68. exactly true	tam doğru
69. should have gone	gitmem gerekirdi
70. shifted	değişmişti
71. stillness	durgunluk
72. mentally tired	zihinsel yorgunluk
73. physically tired	bedensel yorgunluk
74. felt like herself	kendisi gibi hissetti
75. identify	tanımlamak
76. extend her rotation	rotasyonunu uzatmak

77. rhythms	ritimler
78. clinical sense	kllinik anlamda
79. bare	çıplak
80. consultant	uzman doktor
81. took longer than it should have done	gereğinden uzun sürdü
82. booked a flight	uçak bileti aldı
83. required a particular response	belirli bir yanıt gerektirdi
84. halfway through	ortasında
85. I would really like to see you	Seni gerçekten görmek istiyorum
86. less often than he should	gereğinden daha az sıklıkla
87. suburb	banliyö
88. tactfully	nazıkçe, ustalıkla
89. directness	doğrudan konuşma
90. refreshing	ferahlatıcı
91. entirely unlike	tamamen farklı
92. full bloom	tam çiçeklenme
93. aggressively alive	saldırgan biçimde canlı
94. aspect	yön, bakış açısı
95. entirely correct	tamamen doğru
96. should have gone earlier	daha önce gitmiş olmalıydım
97. welcome back	hoş geldiniz
98. ritual	ritüel
99. emotionally	duygusal olarak
100. continuity	süreklilik
101. unremarkable	sıradan, dikkat çekmez
102. held the shape of	şeklini korudu
103. outdoors	dışarıda
104. specialise in	... de uzmanlaşmak
105. unexpected	beklenmedik
106. deciding all year	tüm yıl karar veriyordu
107. emergency medicine	acil tıp
108. find one	birini bulmak
109. anticipated	öngörmüştü
110. formality	resmiyeti

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase

Meaning

1. anchor

A. sınır çizgisinde

2. borderline

B. çapa, tutunma noktası

3. hollowed out

C. ritüel

4. ritual

D. içi boşalmış

5. mandatory

E. zorunlu

6. refreshing

F. ferahlatıcı

7. continuity

G. süreklilik

8. specialise in

H. ... de uzmanlaşmak

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

habit — grief — ready — bench — borderline — conversation

1. Arthur started coming to the _____ the week after

Dorothy died.

2. He said a _____ is something you fall into because the alternative is worse.

3. Priya had made a _____ call while exhausted — nothing catastrophic, but it haunted her.

4. The bench had been the shape of Sunday morning without requiring emotional _____.

5. At the end, she said: 'I'll find a bench.' She had learned what _____ is for.

6. Arthur said: 'You went when you were _____. ' She had given his own wisdom back to him.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Priya speaks to Arthur on their first Sunday together. ____

2. Arthur worked as a doctor before he retired. ____

3. Priya made a mistake that harmed a patient. ____

4. Arthur visits his son in New Zealand during the story. ____

5. Priya decides to leave the city because the rotation ended. ____

6. At the end, Priya shakes Arthur's hand formally. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why did Arthur start coming to the bench every Sunday?

8. What does the phrase 'company without conversation' mean in this story?

9. What mistake did Priya make, and why is she so hard on herself?

10. How does Arthur's engineering background help him contextualise Priya's mistake?

11. What does Priya mean when she says she has 'good words for things that are broken'?

12. What shifts in Priya after her sister's long walk at Christmas?

13. Why does Arthur finally book the flight to New Zealand?

14. What does Arthur realise the bench had been for twenty-two years?

15. What does Priya mean when she says 'I'll find a bench'?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-D 4-C 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. bench 2. habit 3. borderline 4. grief 5. conversation 6. ready

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. T 5. F 6. T

7. Sunday mornings had been Dorothy's time — after she died, he needed something to do with himself on those mornings, and the bench became a weekly anchor.

8. The presence of another person without the obligation to speak — sitting in companionable silence. Arthur had needed this himself and recognised it in Priya.

9. She made a call she knew was borderline at four in the morning when she was exhausted. No one was harmed, but she cannot forgive herself for using poor judgement.

10. He was an engineer — his borderline calls could have caused structural collapse and deaths. He notes that engineers were not allowed to work in such conditions, implying her system fails her.

11. As a doctor, she has clinical language for what is wrong — including, implicitly, what is wrong with herself.

12. She slept eleven hours and felt like herself for the first time since September — physical exhaustion rather than mental rest was what she needed.

13. His son said 'I'd really like to see you' in a way that required a real response — Arthur booked it that night.

14. A weekly ritual that held the shape of Sunday morning without requiring anything of him emotionally — grief made manageable.

15. She has learned that a fixed, quiet point — a bench, a park — is a valuable thing to have, and she will find her own version of it in the new city.